

Workplace Edge - Lesson: Boundary Language. Saying No with Confidence (And Without Guilt)

1. Lesson Overview

Lesson Title: Saying No with Confidence (and Without Guilt)

Pathway (I, We, Us): I

Skill Focus: Boundaries and Assertive Communication

Workplace Challenge: Many professionals, especially in multicultural and team-based settings, struggle to say no at work. Cultural Expectations, the fear of letting others down, appearing unhelpful, or damaging relationships can lead to overcommitment, burnout, and frustration. This lesson builds skills and language to say no clearly, kindly, and appropriately—while understanding when to say yes with intention.

2. Learning Objectives

- Learners will be able to identify common situations where saying no is necessary.
- Learners will be able to use confident, clear and respectful language and tone to set limits at work.
- Learners will reflect on how guilt, cultural expectations, and personal priorities influence their communication choices.

3. Spark (5-10 minutes)

Most of us want to be helpful. But when we say “yes” too often—or too fast—we can end up overwhelmed, overcommitted, or quietly resentful. Let’s check in on your patterns.

Step 1: Personal Poll

Think about the last few months at work. How often have you said “yes” to a task, project, or favour that you didn’t truly have time, energy, or interest for?

Choose one:

- Rarely – I usually pause and think first.
- Sometimes – It depends on who’s asking.
- Often – I feel guilty saying no.
- Almost always – I say yes before I even think.

Burnout Insight:

A Gallup study found that 76% of employees experience burnout at least sometimes. One key contributor? Saying yes too often—especially out of guilt, pressure, or habit. (Gallup, 2020)

Step 2: Reflection (Short Written or Discussion Prompt)

Why do you think you say yes, even when it isn’t the best choice for you?

Leaners choose and reflect on the following responses:

- I didn't want to disappoint someone
- I wasn't sure how to say no politely
- I thought I'd figure it out later
- I felt like I had to say yes to be seen as a good employee
- I wasn't sure what my priorities were
- In my culture it is considered respectful to say yes
- Other _____

This kind of reflection can reveal important emotional or cultural triggers behind our yeses. In fact, research shows that building self-awareness around these emotional patterns is a key part of social and emotional learning (Collaborative for Academic, Social, and Emotional Learning [CASEL], 2023).

Step 3: Cross-Cultural Reflection or Group Discussion

How does your cultural background, family, or community influence your instinct to say yes or no?

- In some cultures, saying no directly is seen as rude or disrespectful, especially to managers or elders.
- In other cultures, being clear and direct—even when saying no—is seen as honest, confident, and professional.

Why it matters: Many people feel torn between being helpful and protecting their time and energy. This tension can create frustration and miscommunication. When we learn how to say no clearly and kindly, we protect our capacity and relationships.

4. Shift (20-30 minutes)

Input (I_Podcast_Tara_SayNoWithConfidence_2025-05-21): "From Yes to Stress: A Lesson in Boundary Language"

Summary: In this audio story, a team member agrees to help a colleague with social media work without setting limits. The story highlights how an unclear yes can lead to hidden resentment and confusion.

Post-Podcast Reflection:

- What emotions or pressures do you think influenced the character's yes?
- When could they have paused and reflected before answering?
- What would you have done in their place?

Activity: Match the Boundary Phrase to the Situation (10 minutes)

Before diving into your own language, explore how boundary tone and phrasing shift based on the situation and communication method.

Instructions (Group or Individual):

Match each workplace situation with the most appropriate boundary phrase and tone. Then reflect:

- Why does that phrase work best here?
- Would you say it differently at your workplace?
- How might your tone shift depending on who's asking—or how?

Workplace Scenario	Channel	Best-Match Boundary Phrase
A peer asks you to help edit a report. You're already behind on your own deadline.	In-person	"I'm on a tight timeline right now. Could I look at it later this afternoon?"
Your manager emails you an extra task that isn't part of your role.	Email	"Thanks for reaching out. At the moment, I don't have capacity to take this on in addition to my current workload."
A colleague texts you after hours for last-minute help.	Text	"I'm offline for the evening but can support you in the morning if that helps."
You're asked to run a presentation with no notice. You're not prepared and it's not in your area of expertise.	In-person	"I don't think I'm the best fit for this one on short notice. Would someone else be available?"

Optional Extension:

Have learners create one *direct* and one *softened* version of each phrase, depending on who they are addressing (e.g., peer vs. manager), or the platform (e.g., chat vs. email).

Facilitator Tip: This activity supports self-awareness of how tone, audience, and communication channel shape our boundary language. Invite cultural input: "How would you handle this in your home culture or language?"

Language Focus: Self-Check, Boundary Phrases & Tone

Self-Check: 4 Questions to Ask Yourself Before Saying Yes

1. What are my current priorities?
2. Do I realistically have time and energy for this?
3. What will I need to say no to if I say yes?
4. Does this align with my role or goals?

Phrase Bank & Tone Tips Handout

Example Boundary Phrases:

- "I don't feel like I'm the right person for this at this time. Can I suggest someone else?"
- "I'd like to help but I don't have the time right now to give this the energy it needs."
- "Thank you for thinking of me, but I can't take this extra work on right now."

Tone:

The words we use matter—but so does *how* we say them. Sometimes a direct response is best. Other times, softening the message helps maintain trust and respect. Tone can change depending on how well you know someone, your workplace culture, or even the format—like email vs. in-person.

Activity:

Review and discuss direct vs. softened versions of boundary phrases. Which would you use and when?

Guided Practice Task:

Learners read or listen to 3 workplace scenarios (see attached worksheet). For each, they:

1. Use the 4 self-check questions.
2. Decide whether a yes or no response is appropriate.
3. Choose one of the target phrases or write their own response.
4. Practice reading it aloud to feel more confident.

Answer Key or Discussion Guide: No fixed answers. Guide includes prompts like:

- What tone did you use?
- How did the wording affect how you felt?
- What helped you decide whether to say yes or no?
- How would you adapt these phrases to suit your work context—like a text, email, or in-person request?
- What emotions came up—guilt, pressure, habit?

Cultural Layer: When Saying No Feels Complicated

We've already touched on how culture can impact how we respond in workplace situations. Let's look at a direct example of this with Rina's Story.

This task helps us notice how culture influences our instincts and shapes how we respond.

Scenario: Rina's Story:

Rina is a new employee at a global company based in Canada. She's from the Philippines, where it's considered polite and respectful to say yes to people in positions of authority.

One afternoon, her Canadian manager asks if she can take on an extra report by end of day.

Rina is already overwhelmed, but she doesn't feel comfortable saying no. She replies, "Yes, I'll do my best," even though it means rushing and staying late.

The report ends up being lower quality than usual. Her manager is surprised and says, "You should've told me you were too busy."

Rina feels caught between her cultural instinct to show respect and the workplace expectation to speak up.

Learner Prompts (Choose Format: Small Group, Breakout, Chat, or Journal):

1. Reflection:
Why do you think Rina said yes? What values or cultural norms might have shaped her decision?
2. Discussion:
Do you relate to Rina in any way? Have you ever said yes out of respect, fear, or habit—even when you wanted to say no?
3. Application:
If you were Rina, what's a respectful boundary phrase you could try instead?
Can you think of one that feels natural in your words and tone?

5. Stretch (20 minutes)**Application Task**

This week:

- Practice saying no using a boundary phrase.
- Practice saying yes, but with clear limits.
- How did each choice feel?
- Did your response match your actual capacity and priorities?
- How was it received?

Journal Prompts:

- How did your yes responses change when guided by your priorities?
- Are you noticing new patterns in your ability to pause and decide before agreeing to something?
- What changed when you said no clearly?
- How can you build on this in future conversations?

Optional Tip:

Re-listen to the podcast and Rina's scenario. Reflect on how you would respond to the situation now.

Downloadable Tool:

"Say No with Confidence" phrase bank + glossary

Boundary Language Worksheet

Match the Boundary Phrase to the Situation Lesson Worksheet

6. Facilitator Notes

***see Facilitator Notes (Expanded doc.)**

Glossary:

- **Tight on time:** I don't have enough time available.
- **Drop from my plate:** Remove a responsibility.
- **Offline:** Outside this meeting or conversation.
- **Extra work:** Additional tasks beyond regular responsibilities.
- **Bandwidth:** The time, energy, or mental capacity someone has available to take on more work.
- **Stretched too thin:** Having too many responsibilities or tasks, making it hard to do any of them well
- **Juggling:** Managing multiple tasks, roles, or responsibilities at the same time—often with difficulty.

7. References (APA format)

Gallup. (2020, March 13). *Employee burnout: The biggest myth*. Gallup.

<https://www.gallup.com/workplace/288539/employee-burnout-biggest-myth.aspx>

Collaborative for Academic, Social, and Emotional Learning. (2023). *State of the field: A practical guide to systemic social and emotional learning*. <https://casel.org/resources/state-of-the-field-2023/>

Transcript/Link/File: I_Podcast_Tara_SayNoWithConfidence_2025-05-21